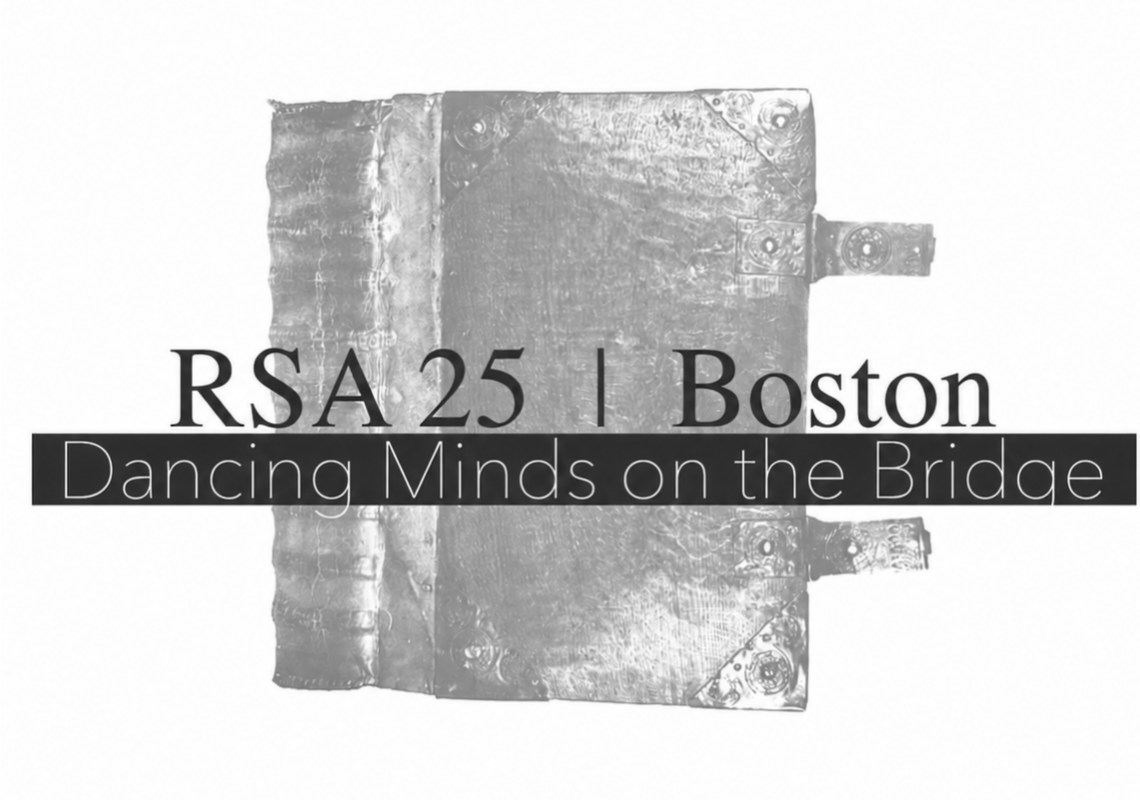

RSA 25 | Boston
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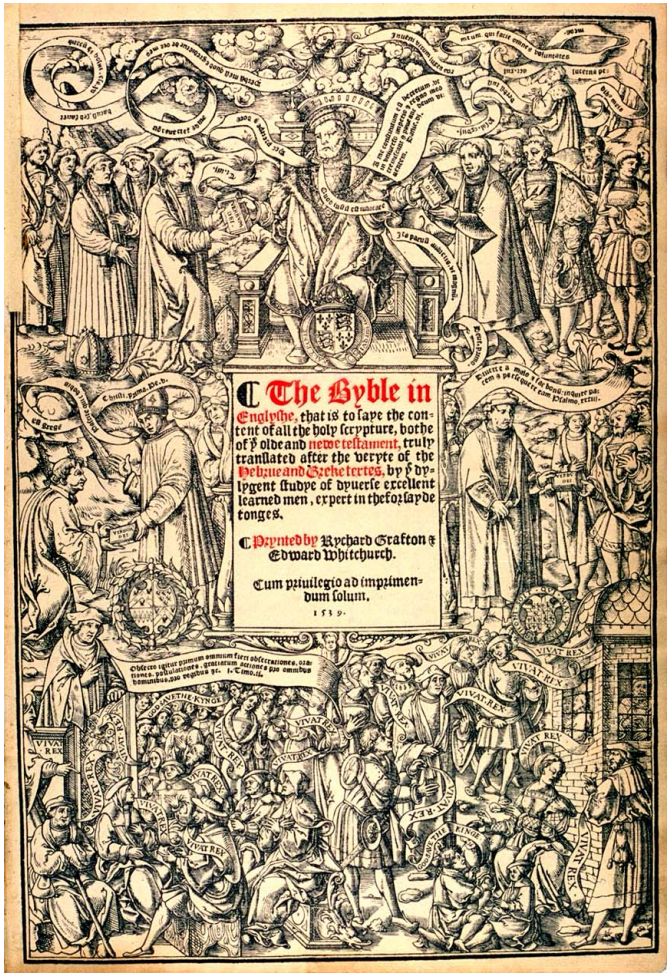
Dancing Minds on the Bridge: Book Industry and Pursuit of Liberty on London Bridge[1]

Sol Sadeghi[2]

In the tightly controlled religious landscape of Renaissance London, the book trade on London Bridge emerged as a crucial catalyst for early intellectual independence. This paper focuses on the role of London Bridge's book shops in distribution of Henry VIII's The Great Bible consistently printed by Royal printer Thomas Berthelet in London following its 1539 release, alongside the establishment of the Stationers' Company in 1557, which regulated the press. Initially supported by patronage from the Catholic Church, during the 16th century, the bridge transformed into a vibrant center for stationers, booksellers, and printing workshops, fostering clandestine exchanges of ideas. Following the 1549 closure of St. Thomas's Chapel—during the Dissolution of the Monasteries—the bridge's tenements facilitated the distribution of literature. By transforming books from elite artifacts into accessible commodities for a burgeoning middle class, the book trade tied to London Bridge significantly influenced debates on personal religious agency. This study highlights how the bridge served not only as a vital physical crossing but also as a crucial space for intellectual exchange.

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[1] The 71st Conference of the Renaissance Society of America - BOSTON, USA
https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20994697
[2] Royal Danish Academy



Title page from the Great Bible, published by Grafton and Whitchurch in 1539.

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Inhabited Bridges in a Privacy Perspective

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